Abhinavagupta (975–1025 CE): a Kashmiri theologian and aesthetician, *Abhinavagupta* belonged to the ***Tantric Trika*** ritual cult, whose doctrines, ***yoga*** and rituals he expounded in his *Tantraloka*. His major philosophical works are commentaries on ***Utpaladeva***'s *Ishvarapratyabhijna-karikas* and the *Malinivijayottara Tantra*. These works present critiques of the dualism of the ***Shaiva Siddhanta*** ritualism, *Vedantic* illusionism that maintains that all normal human experience is infected by ignorance of the truth about reality and the Buddhist rejection of persisting essences, including the soul. Basic to his outlook is a belief that other doctrinal systems are not to be treated as opponents but as aspects of the self-expression of the supreme conscious reality. He formulates a single hierarchy of belief systems in accordance with how closely they approximate to the view that ultimate reality is dynamic universal consciousness.

Abhinavagupta propounded a form of absolute idealism according to which the world derives from a single universal, autonomous (*svatantrya*) and dynamic consciousness that expresses itself in an infinite variety of subjects, objects and acts of awareness. Only ideas are real. The seeker after release from rebirth is to meditate upon the nature of consciousness, oscillating between the illumination of objects (*prakasha*) and reflective awareness (*vimarsha*). In ordinary individual awareness, the representation of what are taken to be external objects, and hence duality, predominates. The adept should reflect that experience of objectivity is just experience or consciousness expressing itself. The subject–object polarity is understood as internal to consciousness. When one realises that the polarity is but a construction within the one consciousness, contracted self-awareness is dissolved along with thinking about the world in terms of external objects, individual subjectivity and agency, and god.